

THE INCITING THREAT, ROUND TWO: SIXTEEN CANDIDATES FROM THE REAL WORLD, ONE FORCED RANKING • 2026-09-05

Disposition of four-keys-threat-real-cases-fable-v2-2026-09-05.md (Fable A to H) and four-keys-threat-real-cases-gpt-v2-2026-09-05.md (GPT 1 to 8), both on prompt v2. Fable v1 (...-fable-v1-...) is superseded; its one novel item, the scullery shower isolator, is the ancestor of Fable A and is absorbed there. Author rankings are hypotheses; this table is the check. Stephen rules; nothing here is approved until he does.

What the real cases settled

- **A wired bath or shower is not a television device; it is a documented husband's method.** Peter Ellis, Cardiff 1993 (bath assembly connected to the mains; the melted plug chain was the tell; the prosecution said a death would have read as a heart attack) and Maria da Penha, Fortaleza 1983 (bath electrocution attempt during convalescence). Both sourced by GPT. That clears gate G for the electrical bath candidates in a way round one could not.
- **The record of pre-rigged domestic mechanisms is thin, and the thinness is the point.** Fable said it, and GPT's nine, once the staging and the product-tampering cases are set aside, come to the same two or three patterns: electricity in the wet room, gas where she sleeps or lights a match, and a heat source left to do its work. A mechanism that reads as wear never gets a case name; that is Violet's position exactly.
- **The first officer reads the story he is handed** (Backhouse, Wangler's "defective heater", Smith's fits, Barlow until the dry pyjamas). The tell that breaks it is a small domestic continuity that the cover story needs and does not have. Violet's eye for a line that used to meet itself is the fictional form of that.
- **Natural gas does not poison** (Fable's technical note). A gas candidate kills by explosion, which needs an accumulation and a flame and a nose that does not work, or by a faulty appliance's carbon monoxide, which is the excluded standard.

The gates (prompt v2)

Gate	Test
A	Inside her house. Not yard, street, workshop, slip, car.
B	Spare-key access and a habit only the four have watched; points at all four equally.
C	Near miss, no fall; she finds it by her own attention, not luck; she keeps working and swimming.
D	A physical detail that says deliberate to her, keepable or photographable.
E	Nothing to an officer or a tradesman; no lab settles it in a day.
F	Had it worked, she dies, and a reader believes it without a paragraph.
G	One tampering; not the standard television murder.
H	Usable by the forgery: Brad can cut or turn the clue without the four noticing.

Disposition

#	Scenario	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	Verdict
F-A	The shower with the lost earth: earth conductor moved to live inside the unit; the house lost its earth when the street was relaid and she said so at her table with all four present; the cut silicone bead	pass	pass, and stronger: the four are the only people who knew the house would not protect her	pass (the bead she ran herself, seen brushing her teeth)	pass (the ribbon of silicone; photographs of the terminal)	pass ("wired wrong from the day it went in"; the earth failure undatable)	pass (certain the moment she pulls the cord; Ellis)	pass (one act; grounded in Ellis and da Penha)	pass (the forgery cuts the paragraph; nothing in it leans anywhere)	LIVE, first
F-C	The brass switch in the passage: rubber cut back, copper folded to the plate; the plate a degree off vertical	pass	pass	pass (the crooked plate: pure Violet)	pass	pass	pass, narrower (wet feet on tile, wet salt hand)	pass (same family as F-A: the story can carry one)	pass	LIVE, the alternative to F-A
F-B	The gas union behind the cookie tin, backed off a quarter turn; the cream paint skin cracked in a ring	pass	pass, strong (the tin cupboard names the four)	pass (tin day)	pass	pass	WEAK: every reader knows gas smells; the dead nose after the sea carries all of it	pass	pass	LIVE, third
G-4	The gas water heater's internal baffle reversed; the soot feather bends off her painted line	pass	pass	pass (the soot line: her eye)	pass	pass	pass	WEAK: a single-tampering cousin of the excluded flue, argued honestly, still carbon monoxide	pass	LIVE, low
G-1	The cooker connection turned one flat off her paint mark	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass	WEAK: smell, and no accumulation story	pass	pass	Absorbed by F-B (the weaker form of the same leak)

#	Scenario	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	Verdict
G-3	The shower control: one conductor moved, screw slot horizontal, crescents in the dust	pass	pass	pass	pass	WEAK: a moved conductor in an earthed house blows the fuse; GPT's own failure line	pass	pass	pass	Absorbed by F-A (the same act; F-A supplies the reason nothing blew)
F-G / G-2	The brass work lamp made live (two versions)	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass	WEAK: a shock, not a death, unless her other hand is placed on the sink	pass	pass	LOW
F-D	The red wheels: two back-boiler valves shut	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass on trust	FAIL: two turns and a physics line, next to the stove exclusion	pass	KILL
G-5	The bedroom gas fire cap turned	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass	WEAK: smell	pass	pass	LOW
F-E	The immersion thermostat to its stop, betting on collapse in a hot bath	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass	FAIL: a bet	pass	pass	KILL
F-F / G-8	The wrong bulb and bent shade; the bent lamp neck on the paper stack	pass	pass	pass	pass	pass	FAIL: probabilistic	WEAK: peg cousins	pass	KILL
F-H	The immersion terminal cap removed in the dark cupboard	pass	pass	pass	pass (the cap with its screw inside)	pass	FAIL: a lottery	pass	pass	KILL
G-6	Crystals in a decongestant capsule (added habit)	pass	pass	pass	pass	FAIL: a lab settles it; and the habit is planted	pass	pass	pass	KILL
G-7	Rodenticide grains in her hidden cigarette	pass	pass (the hidden packet names the four)	pass	pass	FAIL: a lab	WEAK: folklore lethality	pass	pass	KILL

Forced ranking of the survivors

1. **F-A, the shower with the lost earth.** The only candidate that is certain, private, single, keepable, dismissable and real. Certain: the metalwork is live the moment she pulls the cord, and she is standing in an earthed iron bath, wet from the sea. Private: the shower straight from the slip is known to the four; the lost earth, said once at her own table, is known to the four and nobody else, and it is the fact that made the house unable to protect her. Single: one conductor moved. Keepable: the cut silicone bead, and photographs of a green-and-yellow sleeve in the live terminal. Dismissable: the electrician says wired wrong since it went in, the earth went when the street was dug, nobody can date either; the officer writes "unsafe installation, no injury". Real: Ellis, Cardiff, 1993, and the prosecution's own line that the death would have read as a heart attack. It beats F-C because the death is certain rather than likely, and because the lost earth turns "one of you" from an inference into a fact only they held.
2. **F-C, the brass switch.** Pure Violet in its discovery (a plate a degree off vertical) and it needs no planted fact at all. It loses to F-A on certainty: wet feet and a wet hand across the chest is a death a reader will accept, but "certain" is one word too strong. It is the candidate to take if Stephen judges the lost-earth planting too heavy.
3. **F-B, the gas union behind the tin.** The strongest image for "one of you" (the cupboard every one of them has seen opened) and the most Violet tell in either round (her own paint skin cracked in a ring). It loses on the smell: the whole death rests on her nose being dead for an hour after the sea, and a reader who has smelt gas once will not grant it.
4. **G-4, the heater baffle.** The soot feather bending off her painted line is a fine discovery, and the argument that one reversed component is not the two-tampering television murder is honest. It stays carbon monoxide, and Stephen has heard that one.

Recommendation

Rule F-A, the shower with the lost earth. Two canon facts come with it and both are cheap:

- The house lost its earth when the water company relaid Mariner's Row in plastic the previous winter; her electrician told her; she said so at her kitchen table with all four present and never had it done. (One line in the five's Violet paragraph or in the spine's A1; it also gives the genuine letter its "you were all there when I said it".)
- She ran the silicone bead round the shower unit herself, straight as a pinstripe. (Already who she is.)

What it does to the letters. The genuine locker letter gains its threat paragraph: the cut bead, the green-and-yellow in the live terminal, the earth she told them all about, no injury because she looked before she pulled the cord. Brad's forgery cannot turn that paragraph toward Liam (there is nothing in it that leans), so he cuts it whole, and the forged letter's third meeting-claim (which was the ladder) must come from the money and the board rather than from the threat; that is the forgery rebuild, and it is cleaner than before, because the "I know" letter now contains no physical threat at all, which is itself a tell for chapter 7.

What it does to the spine. A1 Day -46/-45: the shower, not the ladder; no injury; Ruby's clinical record of the slip stumble (the innocent fall, Stephen-ruled 2026-09-03) is what the coroner reads. B1 rows 13 and 14 restated. C1 unchanged in shape: her refusal to report is competent (an officer says unsafe installation). Structure p03_04: the Regent marquee stays as the unfinished-job image only.